

UNBROKEN RUN
PM Narendra Modi arrives at the BJP headquarters after leading it to the third successive general election win, Jun. 4, 2024

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**

is the new Parliament building or 40 million houses for the poor, I do it with planning and dedication."

The economic reforms Modi unfolded was marked by audacity and uneven outcomes. Demonetisation in 2016 was the most daring and controversial decision of the Modi years. As a shock therapy meant to formalise the economy and crush black money, its costs were immediate, but its long-term gains remain contested. The roll-out of the Goods and Services Tax was a structural reform of historic scale, collapsing India's fragmented indirect tax regime into a unified framework. Implementation was turbulent, yet over time, GST became an institutional anchor. Agricultural revamp measures, unveiled with similar boldness, ran aground on political resistance and were ultimately withdrawn. It was a rare retreat that revealed the limits of unilateral reform.

Yet Modi's economic vision had not retreated. Infrastructure spending surged as highways, rail corridors, airports and ports reshaped India's physical landscape. Then came COVID-19, a once-in-a-lifetime health and economic crisis, destroying lives and livelihoods, and freezing economic activity overnight. Modi's response combined centralised authority with mass mobilisation alongside one of the world's strictest lockdowns, followed by a vast vaccination drive.

Mistakes were made, particularly during the second wave, but the economic recovery was striking. The state's role changed from being only a regulator to one of an aggressive builder and enabler. Strategic sectors once considered sacrosanct were opened up. Air India returned to private hands. Space and atomic energy were boldly liberalised. The Production-Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme sought to pull India into global manufacturing chains, particularly electronics. By the mid-2020s, India had re-emerged as the fastest-growing major economy, using crisis as catalyst. But the decade also threw up a paradox: a confident state at home, still searching for a breakout role in global trade.

On internal security and national integration, Modi's imprint was unmistakably muscular. The abrogation of Article 370 ended Jammu and Kashmir's special status, fulfilling a long-standing ideological promise while redrawing the map of federal relations. A sustained crackdown almost wiped out Left-wing extremism, which former prime minister Manmohan Singh had once billed as the country's greatest internal security threat.

IF THEY VOTED MODI THRICE, IT WASN'T BECAUSE VOTERS AGREED WITH EVERY DECISION, BUT BECAUSE THEY TRUSTED HIS CAPACITY TO ACT

Meanwhile, religion and identity were never far from the Modi narrative. The construction of the Ram Temple in Ayodhya marked the culmination of a movement that had shaped Indian politics for decades. The ban on triple talaq altered personal law for Muslim women, framed by the